

Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH

Deepening Charges

- A report by US short-seller Hindenburg accused Sebi chairperson Madhabi Puri Buch and her husband Dhaval Buch of holding stakes in offshore funds used in the alleged Adani money siphoning scandal
- A US court accused Adani Green Energy of bribery, and the country's market regulator also charged the company with concealing the alleged malpractice from investors
- The Opposition stalled the winter session of Parliament for several days accusing the central government of protecting Gautam Adani and demanding his arrest

spiracy to violate the FCPA, which has named only Azure executives and CDPQ, a Canadian pension fund that's the largest shareholder in Azure. 'Officials' in Andhra Pradesh, Chhattisgarh, Tamil Nadu, Odisha and Jammu & Kashmir were allegedly induced to execute sale agreements with the Solar Energy Corporation of India (SECI), the Centre's nodal agency for renewable projects, which would then buy the power from Adani and Azure to sell to their discoms.

Denials notwithstanding, the aftershocks lay in wait. Adani Green Energy had to scrap a $600 million bond issue in the US. French oil major TotalEnergies, a partner in Adani's renewable energy and gas distribution businesses, spoke of an embargo on investments till the case was resolved. Borrowings too threatened to get dearer as Moody's slashed the ratings outlook on seven Adani firms from 'stable' to 'negative'; Fitch placed some group bonds on watch for a possible downgrade. Politics took no time to stir up either. The Congress amped up its fusillade against the Narendra Modi government and the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi), the markets regulator, for "protecting" Adani. Rahul Gandhi, leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, demanded Adani's arrest—he said it was clear the tycoon had broken Indian law, not only American law. He also sought a probe against Sebi chairperson Madhabi Puri Buch, accused by Hindenburg of close ties with Adani. Parliament stood stalled for days.

The conglomerate notched a few pluses too in 2024. It continued to grow inorganically, with Ambuja Cement gobbling up two big competitors. Vizhinjam port in Kerala, India's first transshipment port, saw its first cargo ship in July. Adani Green Energy also became the first to surpass 10,000 MW renewable capacity. After the indictment, Adani stocks exhibited resilience, recouping some of their losses. News also filtered in that the prosecutor in charge of the case had resigned. But the way Adani's Africa footprint waxed and waned held out signs: if Tanzania signed a 30-year concession agreement on ports, Kenya pulled out of deals worth $730 million amid much uproar. The indictment had handed a handle to Adani critics—and there may be no dearth of them in the group's journey to a $100 billion-plus (Rs 8.5 lakh crore) capex over the next 10 years. ■